



Cultivated herb gardens can create a colorful, aromatic area with the added benefit of providing a ready supply of fresh herbs to use both medicinally and in cooking.

encourages fresh growth. Pruning and tidying the garden regularly also reduces pests and diseases.

Watering

Water well after planting and then, if needed, once a week (rather than a little each day) in the morning or early evening. Do not overwater as many herbs produce medicinally active constituents in dry conditions. Water dry potted plants thoroughly before planting.

Weeding & Fertilizing

Weeding is necessary since weeds compete with other plants for nutrients and water. Keep beds and containers as free from weeds as possible. Most medicinal herbs should not be fed or mulched as this tends to reduce their therapeutic strength. However, sandy soils should be fed with a good-quality fertilizer to maintain the nutrients in the soil.

Pests & Diseases

Use only organic methods to treat pests, diseases, and insect infestation. Aphids can be eradicated using soapy water or water in which garlic skins have been soaked for 2 days. Separate any infected plants to prevent further contamination.

Sowing Seeds in Containers



1 Fill a seed tray with seed soil mix and water well. Sprinkle on the seeds, covering large seeds with a fine layer of compost. Cover the tray with glass or place in a plastic bag and store in a warm place (up to 70°F/21°C).



2 Once the seeds have germinated, fill a number of pots with soil mix. Gently lift up a seedling, insert it in a small hole in the soil mix, and pack the soil around it. Water thoroughly and do not allow to dry out.

Propagation Methods

There is a wide variety of propagation methods. Choose the one most suited to the plant. When planting, prepare the ground in advance, taking into account the requirements of the individual plant, and the soil, site, and time of year, as well as the anticipated size of the mature plant.

Seed

Seeds can be sown either in containers or in prepared soil in open ground. It is important to time the sowing of seeds to enable seedlings to be planted outdoors when weather and soil become sufficiently warm. Annuals and biennials can be grown with ease from seed and will grow vigorously throughout the summer. Check the germination requirements of perennials before buying seeds, as some varieties germinate easily, while others, such as Siberian ginseng (*Eleutherococcus senticosus*, p. 94), can be far more difficult.

Cuttings

This is one of the most popular methods of propagation. It is suitable for woody perennial

herbs. Cuttings are usually taken from the stem, although some plants may also be propagated from roots. Choose young, healthy plants and take the cutting just below a leaf and stem joint using a clean, sharp knife. Strip off the lowest leaves and dip the stem in hormone rooting preparation before inserting it in suitable soil mix. Some plants are very difficult to propagate this way, so check before attempting this method.

Root Division

This is an easy way to propagate plants that form clumps. Divide spring-flowering herbaceous plants in autumn, and autumn-flowering herbaceous plants in spring. Carefully lift a mature plant, divide it into smaller sections, and replant both the new and the mature plant.

Plants from Produce

Purchase pots of culinary herbs from a grocery or supermarket, split the seedlings into 3 to 4 small clumps, and pot them separately. Fresh roots, such as ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155), or bulblets, such as garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59), can be planted in pots or in prepared ground outside, if temperature allows.

Layering

Layering involves encouraging a shoot or stem to form roots by making a small slit in its underside and burying it, with the growing tip above ground. When the layer roots emerge, remove and pot.

"Mound layering" is suitable for woody herbs such as sage (*Salvia officinalis*, p. 131). Pile free-draining soil over the base of the plant, and when the layered stems form new roots, remove and pot.



Fresh ginger root rapidly produces many new shoots if planted in moist compost in warm conditions above 70°F (21°C).

Offsets

Offsets are produced from most herbs that grow from a bulb or corm, such as garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59). These can be detached during dormancy and replanted.